

Project management vs Product management

In real life business world, the terms “project management” and “product management” are often used in common. They sometimes cause confusion or are even considered synonymous because in reality, these roles are closely related but serve completely different purposes. If we take a look at each one, it will be for us clear why companies usually need both of them.

Similarities

Obviously, project managers and product managers have some thing in common. Both roles require good communication skills, the ability to organize people’s work, and an understanding of how business goals and technical details fit together.

Both roles involve a lot of uncertainty. Deadlines can change, and customer needs can shift. Can say that both managers act like drivers, helping their teams stay on track and making sure the end result meets everyone’s expectations.

Differences

The biggest difference lies in the focus of their work. Project managers are primarily concerned with the process. Their job is to ensure a specific project, whether it be software development, event planning, or a construction project, is completed on time, within budget, and in accordance with agreed-upon requirements. Once the project is complete, the project manager’s work is essentially done. Product managers otherwise look at the big picture. They are interested in the product itself: what features it should have, why customers need it, and

how it should evolve over time. Their role does not end with the release of the product, as products need to be updated, improved, and adapted to changing markets.

Also project management usually has a clear beginning and end, with a short-term or medium-term perspective. Product management is a continuous, long-term process focused on development, strategy, and maintaining the value of the product for users. That's why success is measured differently: project managers are evaluated based on the results of their work, while product managers are evaluated based on their impact on customers and business results.

Examples

In a company which developing a mobile banking app the project manager is responsible for ensuring that designers, programmers and testers keep to deadlines and the app is ready for release date. Project manager's success is measured by whether he managed to stay on schedule and within budget.

Otherwise, the product manager decides what the app should offer: mobile payments, biometric login etc. Product manager's success depends on whether users find the app useful and continue to use it.

Conclusion

Project and product managements have many overlaps, but at the same time they respond to different aspects. Project managers focus on getting the work done, while product managers focus on what needs to be created and for what purposes. The most effective companies recognize that both roles are necessary and complementary.